> **I HAVE REMAINED SECULAR IN MY OUTLOOK AND MY WORK THROUGHOUT MY LIFE...AT MY AGE, I AM LEAST BOTHERED BY THESE CASTEIST ALLEGATIONS**

you are in power, you want everyone to fall in line or subscribe to your ideologies. At my age, I can be my own master. I'm not on social media and have never bothered about whether my statements go viral or not. The citizen has the right to dissent...we should be free to criticise those in power when they do wrong. I feel the democratic spirit must pervade in governance.

Q. You had plans to develop the institute into a premier institution...
A. We had streamlined the courses into an intensive two-year term. A well-equipped projection cum sound mixing studio is now in operation. The professor of film appreciation introduces the very best of world cinema to students. And there are post-screening sessions where the film is discussed so that they learn more about the techniques and art used. We have filled up several vacant posts and now have on the rolls some of the best teachers in the country. Some of them still give guest lectures at prestigious institutes abroad. Training in filmmaking is not just about classroom study or textual knowledge. Filmmakers must watch films with passion to get first-hand knowledge, have heated discussions within student circles. It's a matter of shame that the students here are more charged up about fake and frivolous charges against caste than academics. We also had plans to make a feature film with the best students in each discipline. A full year was to be devoted to it with students getting a post-diploma certificate called 'Advanced course in filmmaking'. The funds required would have been raised privately. It may all sound utopian, but that is the stuff dreams are made of.

Q. Do you feel sad that they have made casteist allegations against you?
A. (*Laughs*) Not in the least. Blind men always see too many elephants. ■



ANI

STERN OFFENSIVE In a massive crackdown on child marriages, around 3,000 people have been arrested so far

ASSAM

NO CHILD'S PLAY

By Kaushik Deka

On January 23, the Himanta Biswa Sarma-led BJP government in Assam launched a massive crackdown against child marriages. Since then, nearly 3,000 people have been arrested based on over 4,000 FIRs registered under the Protection of Children from Sexual Offences (POCSO) Act, 2012, and the Prohibition of Child Marriage Act (PCMA), 2006, against those involved in or facilitating child marriages. The government blitz has resulted in extreme reactions in some cases. A widow, who had been married off as a minor, died by suicide fearing her father's arrest, while another minor girl took the extreme step as her parents, to avoid legal repercussions, didn't let her marry her lover. Women also staged protests in front of a detention camp where arrested husbands and fathers have been held, asking how the families will survive now that breadwinners had been put behind bars.

In the political debate that has ensued, opposition parties have slammed the government overenthusiasm, calling it inhuman. Also, since the crackdown is affecting Muslim-dominated districts—14 out of 31 in the state—many are criticising it as a targeted action against Muslims. While the Congress questioned the BJP-led government's failure to act against agencies that are tasked with protecting child rights, All India United